KERALA

A BIG SEA SNAFU



SHUHAIB PAZHAKULAM

UNDER CURRENTS
The Congress's relay protest in Kollam

By Jeemon Jacob

SAND 'N STORM

- **Centre opens up offshore mining to private players. Kerala's fragile coast up for grabs, protests erupt**
- **A year left for assembly poll, issue could see blowback for Left Front and BJP**

The December 2004 tsunami took the lives of 171 people in Kerala, with one panchayat, Alappad in Kollam district, taking the brunt of it—132 lives lost in a single day. Situated on a narrow 16 km-long strip of land, and sandwiched between the Arabian Sea and the Thiruvananthapuram-Shoranur water canal built in 1880, the coastal village has been protesting against the scourge of offshore black sand mining for over five decades now. But to no avail. In 1955, Alappad covered an area of 89.5 sq. km, today it is a whittled down 8.9 sq. km, the rest of the land taken by the tides.

Now another deadly threat looms on the horizon. As per a new amendment, the Offshore Areas Mineral (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2023, the Centre now has control of the state's coastal waters. The bill has brought several 'reforms', including auctioning of offshore mineral zones to private players through competitive bidding. Three zones are on the block in Kerala; the tender process for mining minerals in 242 sq. km off the Kollam coast was finalised on February 27.

The Kerala coastline is some 590 km long and studies by the Geological Survey of India (GSI) has found reserves of 745 million tonnes of construction-grade sand. This is at various locations off Ponnani, Chavakkad, Kochi, Alappuzha and Kollam, at water depths ranging from 22 to 50 metres. The first locations for the mining is the offshore Parappu in Kollam district. Incidentally, 'Kollam Parappu' or 'Quilon Bank' is a unique deep-sea fishing hub between Kollam and Alappuzha which has been the subject of various studies by the Kerala University of Fisheries and Ocean Studies.

Protests against the Centre's move have been building up since November when the first e-auction was launched. Fishermen, local communities, environmentalists and politicians cutting across party lines are on the warpath. "Enough is enough. The Kerala coastline is fragile and without a credible environmental impact study how can the Centre initiate offshore sand mining?" asks activist and retired professor E. Kunhikrishnan. The Opposition Congress has got a relay protest going in Neendakara in Kollam district. "The Modi government is trying to loot Kerala. Offshore mining will destroy our marine resources and our local communities," Congress leader K.C. Venugopal told INDIA TODAY. The AICC general secretary has much at stake—he represents neighbouring Alappuzha, and its long coast, in Parliament.

The ruling Left Front government is taking flak for "doing nothing, not even passing an assembly resolution to protest the seabed mining move". Experts say the Pinarayi Vijayan-led government has not even ensured enough returns for the state. "In its current form, Kerala will only get the GST from the operations but no share of the revenues from the resources mined off its coast," says a senior official.

With just a year to go for the assembly election, the issue has the potential to kick sand in the faces of both the ruling CPI(M) and the BJP. The Latin Catholic community, which both parties are pursuing for support and whose numbers come in just under a million, are already agitated.

Meanwhile, at Ground Zero, Alappad panchayat president U. Ullas almost seems resigned to his village's fate. "We have tried every possible way to fight the sand 'mafia' in the past but our resistance was brutally crushed by the [state] government. Now the Centre seems to be looking to finish the job," he says. ■